# Through the Prism of the Past: Principles for Applied Economic History

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**Abstract**

Applied economic history begins with a policy problem and draws on historical scholarship to assess responses. We introduce the narrative prism to connect cases, analogies, narratives and scenarios, while distinguishing evidential support from institutional and public interpretation and influence. It draws on applied history, narrative economics, organisational history, and media and memory studies. A sustained application to the Global Financial Crisis develops these principles, alongside a second application to pandemic restrictions as a decision facing policymakers in April 2020. These applications illustrate how historical reasoning can widen policy options, expose the assumptions behind advice and clarify reasons for revision.

**Keywords:** applied economic history; historical reasoning; narrative economics; historical analogy; policymaking.

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# 1 Introduction

Economic and political decision-makers routinely think with history. Earlier crises offer precedents for interpreting present problems and assessing possible responses. Such comparisons can inform policy trade-offs, but they can also encourage overconfident "lessons of history" that obscure differences between episodes and lend authority to poorly grounded policy choices. Economic historians study many of the crises and policy responses invoked in these comparisons. How can they help policymakers assess the relevance and limits of historical precedents?

The response to the Global Financial Crisis illustrates both the value and the risks of drawing policy lessons from the past. As uncertainty mounted, comparison with the Great Depression helped politicians, central bankers, civil servants and policy advisers interpret events and identify responses intended to prevent banking distress from becoming a deeper economic collapse (Eichengreen 2015; Cassis and Schenk 2021; Schenk 2021; O'Sullivan 2022). The comparison offered a compelling reason to act. Yet it also raised questions about which features of the earlier crisis remained relevant, as changes in monetary arrangements, deposit protection and the organisation of finance complicated the analogy.

Scrutinising such comparisons is one task of what we call *applied economic history*: the use of historical reasoning to address contemporary economic policy problems. Unlike inquiry primarily concerned with explaining the past, applied economic history begins with a present economic policy question and draws on existing historical scholarship to assess available choices and their possible consequences. That scholarship will typically have been undertaken for reasons unrelated to its use in policymaking.

The field of applied history shares this starting point, though its literature has overwhelmingly centred on informing decisions in diplomacy and grand strategy (Neustadt and May 1986; MacMillan 2009; Allison and Ferguson 2016). We aim to extend applied history to policy questions with a more explicit economic dimension, drawing on economic history's combination of theoretical reasoning, quantitative evidence and contextual interpretation.[1] Existing work already illustrates this practice

1. "Applied" therefore refers to this purpose, as in applied history, and not to a particular empirical method such as the applied microeconometrics with which economists may associate the term.

without necessarily adopting the label. O'Rourke (2019), for example, brings research on globalisation and its retreat to bear on contemporary threats to economic openness. Researchers studying artificial intelligence and employment also draw on earlier technological transitions (Schneider and Vipond 2023). Vipond (2026) shows how mechanisation in Victorian bootmaking reduced opportunities for new entrants, offering a comparison with recent employment patterns identified by Brynjolfsson, Chandar, and Chen (2025).

Using historical evidence to address a present question requires an account of how events were connected. Narratives organise that evidence into explanations of what happened, why it happened and what followed (Morgan and Stapleford 2023). Invoking the Great Depression to interpret the Global Financial Crisis meant choosing among explanations of the Depression's causes and consequences, each making particular policy responses appear plausible. These interpretations entered a policy debate already structured by familiar stories, institutional commitments and cultural understandings (Shiller 2019; Acemoglu and Robinson 2025).

We introduce the *narrative prism* as a framework for scrutinising historical comparisons and the arguments built upon them. The prism connects the selection of historical evidence and precedents to the examination of shared mechanisms, relevant differences and competing projections. Examining how institutions and public audiences interpret these arguments explains how they are shaped and received, and why even a well-supported comparison may fail to influence a decision. As events unfold, new evidence can prompt reconsideration of both the projection and the historical interpretation supporting it. Following Tosh (2022), we treat historical experience as an "inventory of alternatives": a resource for widening and scrutinising the choices available in the present.

Four bodies of scholarship help explain different aspects of this process. Applied history offers methods for examining comparisons and tracing the historical formation of present problems. Narrative economics examines how stories organise economic reasoning, circulate and influence behaviour. Organisational history explains how institutions construct accounts of their own pasts and use them to interpret new circumstances. Media and memory studies address how historical accounts are framed, contested and remembered beyond their original settings. Together, these literatures

connect the construction of a historical argument to its interpretation and use.

Section 2 introduces the narrative prism. Sections 3–5 develop its principles through the selection of historical comparisons, the examination of mechanisms and competing projections, and the institutional and public uses of historical reasoning. We use the Global Financial Crisis as a means of exposition throughout these sections. Section 6 then shows how the framework can inform an unfolding decision, placing a hypothetical policymaker in April 2020 and drawing only on scholarship published before 2020 to assess pandemic restrictions. Section 7 concludes by drawing together the implications for professional practice.

# 2 The narrative prism

History can unsettle familiar assumptions, as MacMillan (2009) emphasises, but it can also be selectively invoked to confirm them. Neustadt and May (1986) locate this difficulty in the everyday practice of decision-making, where a familiar precedent can supply an interpretation before anyone has examined its relevance. The narrative prism structures this examination around two questions: do the relationships identified in a precedent hold under present conditions, and how does the argument enter policy reasoning?

Our framework distinguishes *cases*, *analogies* and *narratives*, and uses them to develop *scenarios* about possible futures. A historical case is an episode bounded in time and place, distinguished here from the narratives used to explain it. It comprises events, actors, institutions and outcomes, evidence of which survives in contemporary records, reconstructed datasets and subsequent scholarship. These sources reflect earlier choices about what merited preservation or study. A case may attract attention because the episode itself was exceptional, or because a particularly illuminating study made it analytically useful (Morgan 2019). The Great Depression illustrates the distinction between case and narrative. The economic contraction is the case, whereas the competing explanations of its course are narratives.

An analogy establishes a comparison between a historical case and a present problem (Keulen 2023). Its analytical value depends on identifying relevant relationships rather than accumulating surface resemblances (Morgan 1997). Financial distress alone

does not make the Great Depression relevant to the Global Financial Crisis. Instead, the comparison turns on how distress spread through the economy and whether the proposed mechanisms still operated under different institutional arrangements. In practice, analogy and narrative develop together. An explanation of the historical case can suggest a comparison, while examining that comparison can prompt revision of the explanation.

Analogical reasoning examines both positive features, the respects in which two cases are similar, and negative features, the respects in which they differ. These terms describe the comparison, not whether its implications are favourable or unfavourable. Differences help identify the conditions under which a mechanism operates and where an inference breaks down (Morgan 1997; Heede and Polak 2023). Deposit insurance, for example, complicates comparison between the banking panics of the Great Depression and the Global Financial Crisis, because its coverage changes which liabilities and institutions are vulnerable to runs. The comparison can also work in reverse. Bank runs during the Global Financial Crisis can prompt renewed scrutiny of which forms of funding were vulnerable during the Depression. This illustrates what Austin (2007) calls "reciprocal comparison": examining each case through the other can expose assumptions in our understanding of both.

A narrative organises evidence into an account of how events and actions are connected (Morgan and Stapleford 2023). An analogy identifies correspondences between cases; developing it into an argument about the present requires an explanation of why those correspondences matter. Narratives supply this explanation by connecting the features being compared to an account of how each episode unfolded. Morgan (2022) describes narrative as a general-purpose technology for scientific reasoning. In this sense, economic models are themselves narratives, organising accounts of how economic processes work while abstracting from particular historical settings (McCloskey 1983).

Narratives do not belong only to scholars. Within the situations historians study, economic actors construct accounts that shape their expectations, and popular stories can spread like viruses well beyond their original settings (Shiller 2019). Narratives can also be performative: when economic actors use them to interpret situations and guide decisions, they can help shape the processes they describe (MacKenzie 2006). Table 1

Table 1: Four uses of narrative in historical reasoning.

| Use | What it does | Question for analysis |
|---|---|---|
| Scholarly explanation | Organises evidence into an account of causes and consequences. | What supports the proposed relationships, and what would qualify or challenge the explanation? |
| Popular story | Provides a readily communicated account through which people interpret economic events. | How does the account circulate, and what evidence links it to expectations or behaviour? |
| Institutional memory | Selects and interprets past experience in relation to an organisation's identity and responsibilities. | How is the account maintained and revised, and how does it enter organisational reasoning? |
| Public framing | Makes particular features salient when defining a problem, assigning responsibility or presenting responses. | What does the presentation emphasise or leave out, and how do audiences interpret it? |

*Note:* These are overlapping uses of narrative, not mutually exclusive categories of text. The distinctions draw on work on explanation (Morgan and Stapleford 2023), popular economic stories (Shiller 2019), organisational uses of the past (Wadhwani et al. 2018) and framing (Entman 1993).

distinguishes four uses of narrative to clarify what each requires us to investigate. Evidence supporting a scholarly explanation does not establish whether a popular story shaped expectations, an institutional memory guided a decision or a public frame persuaded an audience. A single account can serve several of these purposes, but each claim requires its own evidence.

Finally, a scenario sets out how a situation might develop under specified conditions, including policy choices and other actors' responses. Cases supply historical evidence, analogies identify relevant correspondences with the present and narratives explain why those correspondences might matter. A scenario extends this reasoning towards a possible future, asking how mechanisms identified in the historical case might operate under present conditions, which may differ from those in which they originally operated. Different narratives of the same case may suggest different paths, and even an agreed explanation can support several scenarios under alternative policy choices. Their credibility depends on the supporting evidence and assumptions, not on narrative coherence alone. Scenarios matter most when decisions must be made before events

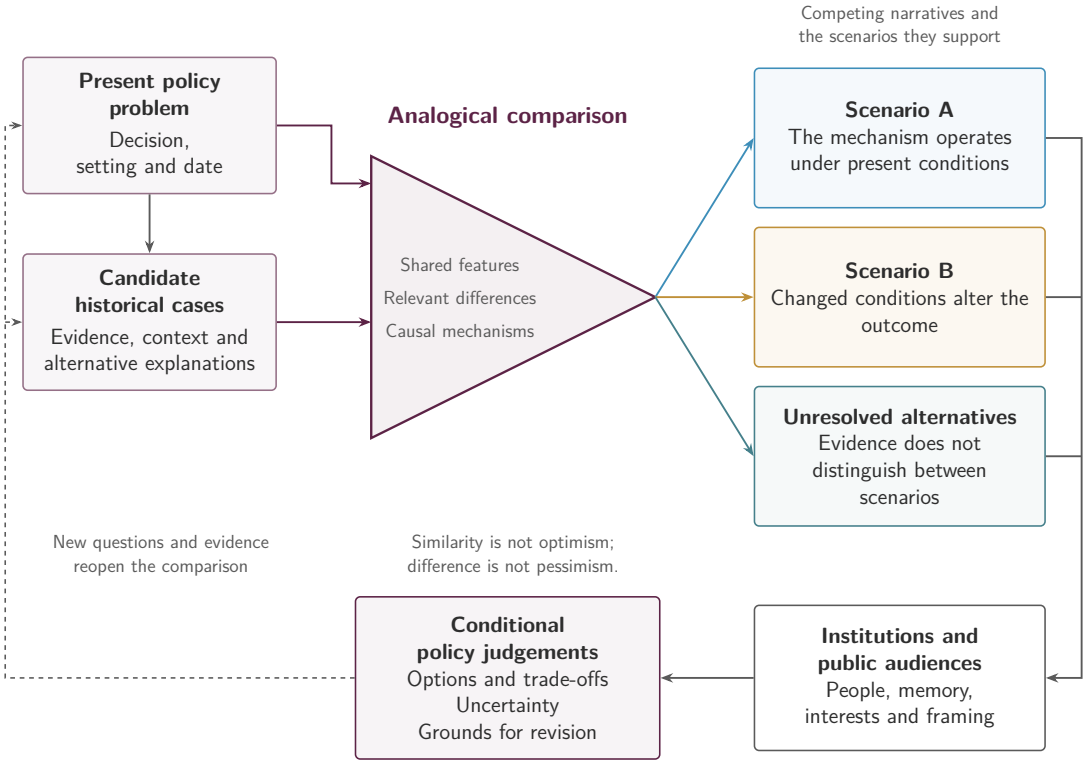



Figure 1: The narrative prism. Historical cases inform analogies and competing narratives, which support scenarios about possible futures. Institutional and public interpretation shapes conditional policy judgements, while new questions and evidence reopen the comparison.

have run their course. Ferguson's (2023) account of the deliberations surrounding Lehman's collapse illustrates how historical analogies informed assessments of what might follow from the choices available.

Figure 1 separates activities that interact continuously in practice. An initial interpretation of a present problem may suggest particular cases, while a difference between episodes may prompt a new search or a reformulation of the problem. Which cases are selected depends on the present question, accumulated scholarship, available evidence and participants' knowledge. Familiarity can make a precedent accessible without making it the most informative comparison (Tversky and Kahneman 1973; Eichengreen 2012). During the Global Financial Crisis, the Great Depression was a comparison ready to hand. Its prominence therefore raises a question: was it chosen because it was relevant to the problem, because it was familiar, or both?

Throughout this process, historical arguments pass through institutional and public

interpretation. Organisations possess accounts of their own histories that shape how their members understand responsibilities, recognise problems and assess possible action. Such accounts can also be mobilised strategically to justify decisions (Suddaby, Foster, and Trank 2010; Wadhwani et al. 2018). Outside these organisations, public audiences encounter historical comparisons through frames that make some aspects of an episode more salient than others (Entman 1993). These processes influence which precedents are initially selected as well as how subsequent arguments are received. Individuals connect these settings, bringing historical expertise into discussion and lending it authority through their positions.

The involvement of institutions and public audiences connects applied history with public history. Kaal and van Lottum (2021) trace the intertwined development of these two fields, noting that the terms have often been used interchangeably and that public history became a broader umbrella for historical work beyond academia, including museums, community projects and oral history. Our emphasis on addressing present problems distinguishes applied history within this wider practice, rather than establishing a firm boundary between the two. Work on the continuing consequences of past injustice, for example, can serve both purposes.

Working with policymakers and public audiences can also change the direction of historical research. Present concerns influence the questions historians ask, the evidence they reconstruct and the interpretations they reconsider. How present concerns enter explanations of the past has itself become an object of historical inquiry (Armitage 2023; Rubin 2017). Policy responses and their consequences can, in turn, challenge the comparisons that helped justify them. Engagement with policy thus does more than draw on existing economic history; it can generate questions for further research (Eichengreen 2015; Taylor 2026).

Explaining an analogy's influence and assessing its quality are distinct tasks. A weak analogy can dominate a policy debate, and a well-supported one can be ignored: influence does not establish analytical soundness, nor does soundness guarantee influence. The next three sections develop principles for selecting evidence, evaluating comparisons and communicating their implications and limits.

# 3 Selecting and constructing historical comparisons

The selection of historical comparisons begins by defining the policy question. Treating a crisis simply as "another Great Depression" risks letting a familiar episode supply the diagnosis before the relevant relationships have been examined (Eichengreen 2012, 2015). Breaking the Global Financial Crisis down into connected questions (how to contain runs on financial institutions, how to sustain aggregate demand or how to prevent international contagion) changes the search for precedents. Each question highlights different features of earlier crises and may bring different historical cases into view. The question shapes the comparison and may change as the inquiry proceeds.

Reconstructing a policy decision also requires fixing the comparison in time. An applied economic historian evaluating a past decision must ask what evidence and interpretations were available to decision-makers at that moment: later scholarship can assess their reasoning or reveal alternatives, but was unavailable at the time. During the Global Financial Crisis, Romer (2009) used research on the 1930s, including her own, to argue for further stimulus. Writing retrospectively, O'Sullivan (2022) instead examined the origins and influence of the monetary interpretation informing such responses.

Once the question and date are set, historical reasoning can proceed in two complementary ways. Mens (2023) distinguishes *analogy*, which compares situations, from *genealogy*, which traces the historical processes through which a present situation developed. Comparing financial distress in 2008 with the banking crises of the 1930s is an analogical exercise. Tracing how financial institutions and regulatory arrangements evolved before 2008 is a genealogical one. Applied economic history needs both, and each informs the other: tracing present arrangements helps identify useful comparisons and shows how earlier choices constrain current options. Accounts of path dependence and lock-in identify one mechanism through which this can happen, as adoption generates advantages that encourage further adoption and make alternatives harder to pursue (David 1985; Arthur 1989). A policy feasible in one setting may therefore be difficult in another because the two economies followed different historical paths.

Genealogy can also expose the inherited understandings that shape how policymakers see their options. Berman (2022) shows how an "economic style of reasoning", centred on concepts such as efficiency and competition, acquired influence

within American public policy, shaping both the questions policymakers asked and what counted as a persuasive justification for action, while marginalising alternatives grounded in equality or the redistribution of power. Because the search for historical precedents takes place within these understandings, examining how they developed can bring neglected alternatives into view.

Why do some historical comparisons command attention in policy debates while others are overlooked? Part of the answer lies in how arguments are made and who makes them. McCloskey (1983) argues that economists' formal accounts of their methods overlook how they persuade one another in practice, using analogy, metaphor and appeals to authority alongside mathematical and empirical arguments. Fourcade, Ollion, and Algan (2015) connect economists' authority to the organisation of their discipline, its internal hierarchies and its privileged access to policymaking. An argument's influence can therefore depend partly on the professional standing of its advocates. Selecting a precedent is itself part of persuasion: invoking the Great Depression makes the stakes of inaction appear different from those suggested by a comparison with an ordinary recession. Economic historians applying their research to policy take part in this process themselves. They therefore need to ask not only whether a comparison is supported by evidence, but also how its rhetoric and the authority of those advancing it shape the diagnosis.

One direct channel into policy is the presence of economic historians in decision-making roles. Reflecting on the Global Financial Crisis as Chair of the Federal Reserve, Bernanke (2010) connected his earlier research on Depression-era banking distress to the importance of stabilising the financial system, and Romer (2009) brought her historical expertise into policymaking as Chair of the Council of Economic Advisers. Their speeches document public reasoning rather than establish its influence on decisions. Working within these institutions can also create opportunities to question how a problem has been defined, a contribution that Green (2016) advocates for historians in policy formulation. The reconstruction of data provides another channel. Long-run data series place an apparently exceptional event within a wider distribution of experiences, revealing patterns that a short observation period would conceal (Reinhart and Rogoff 2009; Jordà, Schularick, and Taylor 2017). Reflecting on his service on the Bank of England's Monetary Policy Committee, Taylor (2026),

a coauthor of the latter study, describes how accumulated scholarship informs policy assessments while policy concerns stimulate new historical questions. Establishing a problem's scale and duration can thus challenge the initial diagnosis before a precedent is chosen.

Yet economic history is more than a source of longer datasets or cases for testing economic theory. As Monnet (2021) argues, historical inquiry can also question how the present problem and its possible solutions have been defined. He points to credit controls: instruments now associated with financial stability previously served monetary and distributive objectives. Recovering those earlier uses invites scrutiny of the purposes assigned to them today, rather than simply supplying evidence of their effectiveness.

The historical evidence available for comparison can itself limit this reconsideration, because what we know about earlier crises depends on which records survived and which institutions researchers studied. For example, reliance on data from a few large French banks long understated the severity of banking distress in France during the Depression. By reconstructing balance sheets for more than 300 banks, Baubeau et al. (2021) change the French experience available for comparison with the Global Financial Crisis. Expanding coverage does not resolve every difficulty, however. Official statistical categories themselves reflected governmental priorities, as Tooze (2001) shows by tracing their development in Germany from the Kaiserreich to the Nazi regime. What appears to distinguish two crises may therefore owe something to the records used to study them.

Archival silences can begin well before records reach historians. In his influential account of power and historical knowledge, Trouillot (1995) examines how the Haitian Revolution was marginalised, and shows how historians can perpetuate such exclusions through their own research conventions. Drawing on Trouillot, Frost, Verhoef, and Durepos (2026) argue for attention to evidence outside formal archives, which can bring neglected historical experiences into the comparisons used to inform policy. Research incentives introduce a parallel form of selection. Humphries (2026) argues that the privileging of particular identification strategies can narrow the questions economic historians investigate and the methods they regard as legitimate. For applied work, this creates a potential "streetlight effect": cases may enter the repertoire because their evidence accommodates a favoured research design, rather than because they offer the

most informative comparison with the present problem. A carefully identified result may address only part of a broader policy problem, while archival or comparative work may reveal other relevant institutions and mechanisms.

Finally, a single precedent rarely answers every question raised by an unfolding crisis. James (2013) shows how the geographical centres and forms of distress changed as the Depression and the Great Recession unfolded, so that a precedent useful for one phase may be less useful for another. Cassis (2026) distinguishes the Depression's usefulness for understanding how policy can prevent financial distress from becoming an economic catastrophe from its limitations as a precedent for explaining the origins of the financial crisis. Widening the comparison set can help. During the Global Financial Crisis, deposit insurance had largely prevented the retail bank runs familiar from the 1930s, yet runs emerged among institutions dependent on short-term market funding (Bernanke 2010). This gave the Panic of 1907 particular relevance: trust companies outside the protections available to established banks had become a focus of instability (Bernanke 2013; Bruner and Carr 2007). Despite substantial differences between the episodes, 1907 directed attention towards vulnerabilities that a focus on protected retail deposits might obscure.

Looking beyond the United States helps separate relationships intertwined in the American experience. The Netherlands avoided a banking crisis comparable to that of the United States, yet its adherence to gold until 1936 prolonged the Depression (Fliers and Colvin 2022). South Africa remained on gold until late 1932, yet subsequently experienced an exceptionally strong recovery, its position as a major gold producer amplifying the gains from depreciation (Eichengreen 2021; Swanepoel and Fliers 2021). The Dutch case helps separate monetary constraints from banking instability, while the South African case draws attention to how the structure of production conditioned the effects of monetary policy.

Building a comparison set is therefore an exercise in diagnostic design. Rather than relying on a single headline analogy, the applied economic historian assembles several cases, such as the Depression in the United States, the Panic of 1907, and the contrasting Dutch and South African experiences. Each case exposes different relationships, while differences may undermine the proposed analogy. Selecting these cases begins the argument; their relevance depends on how they are explained.

# 4 Mechanisms and competing projections

Selecting relevant historical cases is only the first step. A single historical episode can support several causal explanations, each with different implications for policy and for what might happen next. Applied economic history requires judging how those proposed mechanisms interact and whether the conditions they depend on hold in the present.

Consider how a single interpretation of a past crisis can come to shape policy thinking. O'Sullivan (2022) traces how Friedman and Schwartz's (1963) *A Monetary History of the United States* shifted responsibility for the Great Depression from systemic failures of capitalism to the Federal Reserve's failure to prevent monetary contraction. What began as a challenge to prevailing ideas subsequently became an orthodoxy, helping legitimate extraordinary monetary intervention during later crises. Yet its usefulness to policymakers did not settle the historical questions O'Sullivan reopens.

The Depression is a single episode with several causal explanations, not a set of repeated observations that isolate each mechanism's contribution. Alongside monetary contraction, prominent accounts emphasise international monetary constraints (Temin 1991) and the political foundations of banking fragility (Calomiris and Haber 2014). These accounts need not be mutually exclusive: monetary contraction could intensify distress in vulnerable banks while the monetary regime constrained intervention. Application requires making a judgement about how these explanations fit together and which relationships remain relevant in another setting. As Eichengreen (2015) shows, the 1930s were read selectively during the Global Financial Crisis. Bringing the accounts together helps examine what a favoured interpretation leaves out, without assuming that all explanations deserve equal weight.

How, then, can competing mechanisms be examined and translated into conditional scenarios? The Global Financial Crisis illustrates this inquiry through three perspectives: the spread of financial distress, the constraints imposed by monetary arrangements and the passage from intervention to recovery.

First, when assessing financial vulnerability, comparing several historical cases helps separate why institutions become vulnerable from how distress spreads. In the United

States, banks failing in 1930 had often already been weakened by regulatory constraints and regional economic difficulties (White 1984), while interbank withdrawals amplified distress (Mitchener and Richardson 2019). Reading the Depression alongside the trust company runs of 1907 (Bruner and Carr 2007) extends attention to runnable funding beyond protected retail deposits, so that one comparison refines another.

Canada, which avoided a banking crisis during the Depression, offers a further contrast. Bordo, Redish, and Rockoff (2015) connect its stability across several crises to the development of its banking structure and regulation, shifting attention from emergency intervention to the arrangements that limited vulnerability, and to whether they could work in another financial system. For the Global Financial Crisis, these comparisons distinguish tasks that a single analogy might blur. Liquidity support may interrupt transmission without resolving impaired balance sheets (Bernanke 2013), while repairing those balance sheets need not change the arrangements that generated vulnerability.

Second, comparative cases and explicit counterfactuals help distinguish the constraints of a monetary regime from banking vulnerability. Comparing Dutch experience in the 1920s and 1930s illustrates this separation. Colvin, de Jong, and Fliers (2015) link Dutch banking distress in the 1920s to banks' balance-sheet choices and business strategies. During the Depression, however, the absence of comparable banking instability did not spare the Netherlands a prolonged downturn: the country remained on gold until September 1936, among the last to leave. Fliers and Colvin (2022) show that its central bankers combined substantial gold reserves with restrictions on capital mobility to retain operational flexibility and sustain the existing parity, at considerable economic cost. Their counterfactual analysis of exchange-rate, interest-rate and reserve policies finds that leaving gold alongside Britain in 1931 would have avoided a deepening of the Dutch Depression. Conditional on the specified alternative, the result distinguishes flexibility within a regime from willingness to change it.

Fogel (1970), defending the methods of the New Economic History, argued that counterfactual judgements were already embedded in historical explanation; making them explicit exposes the assumptions behind claims about the importance of a particular institution, event or policy. Their credibility depends on whether evidence

supports the relationships used to infer the alternative outcome under changed conditions. For the Dutch case, this means modelling how an earlier departure from gold could have affected the economy, rather than treating departure itself as sufficient to establish a better outcome.

Like countries maintaining gold parity during the Depression, euro area members during the Global Financial Crisis could not devalue unilaterally while remaining within their monetary arrangements. Monetary support, however, depended on a shared central bank. O'Rourke (2019) notes that the financial and eurozone crises renewed attention to the Depression as a sudden stop in international capital flows. This adds a question about how monetary constraints interacted with the loss of external funding: which responses remained available, and could they offset the resulting fall in spending? The Dutch and South African cases described previously help distinguish the scope for monetary adjustment from its likely effects.

Looking closely at mechanisms also cautions against relying on a single indicator of stability. Even without a wave of bank failures in the 1930s, deposits in several countries moved towards savings institutions. Degorce and Monnet (2024) interpret this movement across countries primarily as a flight to safety, whereas for the Netherlands Peeters and de Vicq de Cumptich (2025) give greater weight to relative interest rates and government policies that encouraged the reallocation. This returns us to the problem of evidence discussed in Section 3: a system that appears stable when judged by bank failures may look less so when deposit movements and credit provision enter the account. The mechanism matters for policy. Restoring confidence might not reverse deposit movements sustained by policy incentives, while the survival of banks need not ensure continued access to credit.

Third, historical mechanisms can inform conditional scenarios for recovery. Why might spending remain depressed after financial stabilisation? Research on the 1930s points to expectations of deflation that keep real interest rates high, a mechanism examined by Romer and Romer (2013) building on the monetary interpretation of Friedman and Schwartz (1963), and to household uncertainty that can hold back purchases of durable goods even when borrowing costs fall (Romer 1990). Resolving the immediate financial emergency would therefore leave reasons for continued stimulus, consistent with Romer's (2009) warning against withdrawing it prematurely.

Weak demand could also coexist with improvements in productive capacity: Field (2011) documents technological and organisational advances alongside infrastructure investment during the Depression. Assessing intervention thus requires distinguishing what could revive spending from what could support growth over a longer period.

During the Global Financial Crisis, economic historians used such mechanisms to assess what might follow before the outcome was known. In spring 2009, Eichengreen and O'Rourke (2009) compared the initial declines in global production, trade and equity markets with those of the Depression, stressing that different policy responses could change the subsequent course of events. Crafts and Fearon (2010) likewise examined what Depression research could contribute to contemporary policy. Revisiting the comparison as recovery faltered, O'Rourke and Eichengreen (2012) argued against premature fiscal consolidation and monetary normalisation. This was applied economic history in real time: using research on an earlier episode to assess an unfolding policy problem and revising the assessment as new evidence emerged.

Later scholarship allows retrospective assessment of those judgements, although it was unavailable to policymakers constructing scenarios at the time. Eichengreen et al. (2021, ch. 12) argue that fiscal consolidation after the Global Financial Crisis was especially damaging where exchange-rate constraints and limited monetary accommodation prevented other sources of demand from offsetting spending cuts. Eggertsson and Egiev (2025) specify how policy effects in a liquidity trap depend on the monetary and fiscal regime and central bank credibility.

When translating historical mechanisms into scenarios, applied economic historians must also consider expectations. The same intervention could elicit different responses depending on whether households and investors anticipated recovery or expected recent difficulties to persist, differences that Nützenadel and Streb (2026) connect to actors' experience, information costs and the uncertainty they face. Evidence of market behaviour cannot by itself distinguish these processes. Bianchi (2020), for example, identifies a Depression-like regime in asset-return patterns during the Global Financial Crisis, with a reversal in March 2009. This challenges the continued applicability of that historical pattern, but return patterns alone cannot show how investors formed their expectations or whether a Depression narrative influenced them.

Even the metaphors used to describe a mechanism can direct attention towards some

Table 2: Three perspectives on the Global Financial Crisis.

| Perspective | Cases and scholarship | Mechanism | Relevant differences | Conditional implication |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Financial vulnerability and transmission | US panics of 1907 and the 1930s, and Canadian resilience (White 1984; Bruner and Carr 2007; Bordo, Redish, and Rockoff 2015; Mitchener and Richardson 2019). | Weak balance sheets create vulnerability, and withdrawals and financial connections propagate distress. | Deposit insurance protects retail deposits, whereas runnable wholesale funding and the organisation of banking change the location of risk. | Liquidity support may interrupt runs, but impaired balance sheets and institutional sources of fragility require separate attention. |
| Monetary constraints | The Dutch gold-standard commitment and South African recovery (Eichengreen 2021; Swanepoel and Fliers 2021; Fliers and Colvin 2022). | Monetary commitments restrict adjustment, while production structures affect the gains from a policy change. | Gold parity no longer constrained GFC responses in the same way, though other institutional limits remained and gold production was specific to South Africa. | Identify which constraints can be changed and how the surrounding economy affects the consequences. Operational flexibility need not imply willingness to change the regime. |
| Intervention and recovery | Depression contraction and recovery (Friedman and Schwartz 1963; Romer 1990; Field 2011; Romer and Romer 2013), compared with subsequent GFC evidence. | Deflation expectations and uncertainty restrain spending, while investment and technological change shape productive capacity. | Policy regimes, credibility, financial repair and sources of uncertainty differ across episodes. | Stabilisation need not secure sustained recovery. Assess remaining barriers to demand alongside the effects of intervention on future productive capacity. |

*Note:* The table summarises the studies cited in Sections 3–4. It presents our retrospective comparison, including later scholarship, rather than an inventory of evidence available in 2008. The three perspectives can complement one another, and no single row supplies a general prescription.

of its parts. Bill Phillips's MONIAC machine gave physical form to a hydraulic account of the economy, using water flowing through tanks and pipes to model monetary flows (Phillips 1950).[2] The familiar description of finance as the economy's plumbing similarly makes interrupted flows and their restoration easier to understand. As McCloskey's (1983) examination of metaphor in economic reasoning shows, such selectivity operates even within formal models. The plumbing metaphor can make restoring lending look like a sufficient technical repair, while saying less about who owns the pipes, who bears the losses when they fail and what incentives lay behind banks' risk-taking.

Table 2 brings together the three perspectives. Taken together, they show why applied economic history cannot rely on a single lesson: an account of how distress spreads does not by itself explain whether intervention will restore spending or sustain recovery. Stopping a run, adjusting a monetary regime and reviving demand involve distinct mechanisms, and application requires judging how they interact and where differences between settings limit their relevance. The resulting scenarios set out possible developments under specified conditions and remain open to revision.

# 5 Institutions, individuals and public reasoning

Even a carefully constructed historical argument enters organisations and public debates already shaped by their own accounts of the past. For a central bank, an earlier crisis may signify a failure to act, a successful defence of monetary stability or a warning about political interference. These accounts help define institutional responsibilities and make some responses to a new problem more readily intelligible than others. Organisational historians describe this as an active process, in which people select and reinterpret the past as they explain their organisation's position and justify its decisions (Suddaby, Foster, and Trank 2010; Hansen 2012; Wadhwani et al. 2018). Decker, Hassard, and Rowlinson (2021) emphasise the distinction between researching past events and researching their subsequent remembrance.

Institutions also turn recent crises into precedents of their own. Once interpreted through earlier crises, the Global Financial Crisis now supplies comparisons for later

2. A working Monetary National Income Analogue Computer is on display in London's Science Museum: see https://collection.sciencemuseumgroup.org.uk/objects/co64127/phillips-economic-computer.

ones. Remembering a crisis does not necessarily preserve a stable account of what caused it or what was learned. Cassis and Schenk (2021) distinguish the persistence of crisis memories from their use in subsequent decisions, while Schenk (2021) examines the uneven processes of using and forgetting the past after 2008. Surveying 150 senior financial services executives in 2023, Cassis (2026) finds that memories of 2008 persisted in reported changes to risk management, business models and internal discussions, and that 83% of respondents regarded post-crisis regulation as an effective or very effective reminder of the sector's earlier risk-taking. An apparent lesson may nevertheless outlive the circumstances qualifying it.

Historical accounts also take shape while a crisis is still unfolding. In his study of the 1931 European financial crisis, Hansen (2025) follows how central bankers and other contemporary observers made sense of recent events and drew lessons for an uncertain future, connecting them to wider understandings of finance. Here, historical interpretation and projection develop together before an explanation has settled. An action mistaken in hindsight may have followed from an account plausible to those involved, given their information and expectations.

Different actors may also interpret the same crisis story differently. Read alongside Hansen (2025), Nützenadel and Streb's (2026) discussion of anticipation suggests that a central bank's account of why it is intervening may differ from how lenders or households interpret the move. Eliaz and Spiegler (2020) model narratives as causal accounts that connect actions to consequences, and whose appeal depends partly on the favourable outcomes people expect from the policy they support. A historical analogy may therefore win support for reasons other than the strength of its evidence. Establishing whether this happened during the Global Financial Crisis would require evidence about the accounts economic actors encountered and how they responded.

Over time, selective institutional memories can narrow the options considered legitimate. Mee (2019) traces the development of a "monetary mythology" in post-war West Germany that connected a selective interpretation of interwar experience to the case for central bank independence. The Bundesbank's authority developed through political struggles over monetary policy, rather than simply through the survival of inflation memories. Such institutional stories affect how new historical arguments are received: a comparison consistent with an organisation's understanding

of its responsibilities may meet a different reception from one that challenges it. In the eurozone crisis, Eichengreen et al. (2021, ch. 12) identify the assumption that advanced economies do not restructure their debts as one obstacle to an earlier Greek restructuring. Historical scrutiny could challenge that assumption, although it would not remove the creditor exposures and political interests that also sustained resistance.

What happens when economic historians bring their expertise inside these institutions, as Ben Bernanke, Christina Romer and Alan Taylor did? Individual appointments connect scholarship and policy directly, but they raise two questions for applied economic history. The first is institutional continuity. Expertise may enter through individuals, but retaining it requires recording their reasoning and passing it to successors; an organisation may retain a crisis policy without knowledge of the historical argument that informed it or an understanding of the conditions under which it was considered appropriate.

The second is the difference between using research to inform a decision and using it to justify one. Boswell (2009) distinguishes knowledge used to inform policy from knowledge used to substantiate existing preferences or establish organisational authority. When a central banker cites the Great Depression in a public speech, that speech documents public reasoning; it does not show that historical scholarship changed the decision.[3] Evidence of influence might instead come from deliberations showing how a comparison altered the diagnosis, the alternatives considered or the reasons for choosing among them.

Historical claims must also acquire credibility with their audiences. Studying German business in colonial India, Lubinski (2018) shows that organisations' historical claims gained credibility through interaction with multiple audiences and the narratives already circulating among them; organisations could not simply deploy history at will. A central banker claiming to have learned from earlier mistakes faces a similar difficulty. Audiences bring their own experiences to that claim and may have different reasons to trust or question it.

In public debate, framing makes particular aspects of a problem salient, linking

3. European Central Bank President Christine Lagarde (2025), for example, cites Quinn and Turner's (2020) history of financial bubbles to argue that investment booms can leave lasting technological benefits, supporting her case for faster adoption of artificial intelligence in Europe. This citation does not establish whether the book helped shape her position or supplied a justification for a position already reached.

diagnosis to responsibility and remedies (Entman 1993). Calling 2008 "another Great Depression" conveyed the danger of inaction without explaining the historical basis of that warning, and the same historical reference can support competing responses. Renewed press attention to 1929 in the late 1970s accompanied challenges to the Keynesian consensus (Telesca and Cassis 2026), and banking turmoil in 2023 revived conflicting readings of 2008: some commentators blamed monetary expansion and regulation, others the weakening of regulatory safeguards (Cassis 2026). The persistence of such comparisons may also reflect how they are remembered. Graeber, Roth, and Zimmermann's (2024) experiments find that stories affect beliefs longer than statistics because they are better recalled, suggesting why a historical account may outlast its accompanying evidence.

Public controversy also shows that crisis policies involve more than technical judgement. Supporting banks in 2008 could be understood both as preventing economic collapse and as protecting institutions associated with the crisis, a disagreement involving judgements about who deserves support and who should bear the losses. The studies collected by Cassis and Telesca (2018) place financial elites within their changing political and social settings, examining their expertise and influence alongside competence and accountability. Historical comparisons centred on restoring stability may leave these concerns unaddressed. Taking them seriously can change the historical inquiry itself. Drawing on what Dillon and Craig (2023) call "storylistening", the gathering and interpreting of narrative evidence to inform public reasoning, economic historians could investigate how people relate a present disruption to earlier experiences of insecurity, institutional failure or recovery. Such accounts provide evidence about expectations that expert discussion may have missed, and may suggest different historical comparisons.

Table 3 shows how the four uses of narrative introduced in Section 2 (scholarly explanation, popular story, institutional memory and public framing) overlap in the financial crisis discussion. A scholarly interpretation of the Depression may become part of an institution's account of its responsibilities, acquiring authority beyond the evidence originally supporting it, so historians engaging with policymakers rarely start with a blank slate. Wynant's (2025) research on public institutions in Belgium examines how historians and stakeholders can reconsider such inherited accounts

Table 3: Uses of narrative in the Global Financial Crisis application.

| Use | Historical account | Use in the GFC discussion | What the evidence establishes |
|---|---|---|---|
| Scholarly explanation | Monetary contraction and financial disruption as explanations of the Depression (Friedman and Schwartz 1963; O'Sullivan 2022). | Supplies mechanisms for assessing the risks of inaction and the case for intervention. | Supports examination of particular mechanisms, though its authority or adoption does not settle their applicability. |
| Popular story | A simplified Depression lesson: financial collapse can bring economic catastrophe (Eichengreen 2015). | Makes a complex historical argument readily available as a warning about the unfolding crisis. | Identifies a simplified lesson, without establishing its prevalence or its independent effect on household or investor behaviour. |
| Institutional memory | The Federal Reserve's reading of Depression-era failures, articulated by Bernanke (Bernanke 2010). | Connects historical expertise to the institution's responsibilities for financial stability. | The speech records an institutional interpretation. Tracing its effect on particular decisions requires evidence of deliberation and use. |
| Public framing | Selective readings of the 1930s as warnings about contraction, debt or inflation (Eichengreen 2015). | Directs attention towards different dangers and makes different responses appear warranted. | Documents competing uses of the past. A shared precedent does not establish agreement or an effect on policy. |

*Note:* The table applies the distinctions in Table 1 to the preceding discussion. The accounts are paraphrases, not quotations. A single account can serve several uses, and identifying its explanation or public invocation does not by itself establish its influence on decisions. Table 2 separately summarises mechanisms and conditional implications.

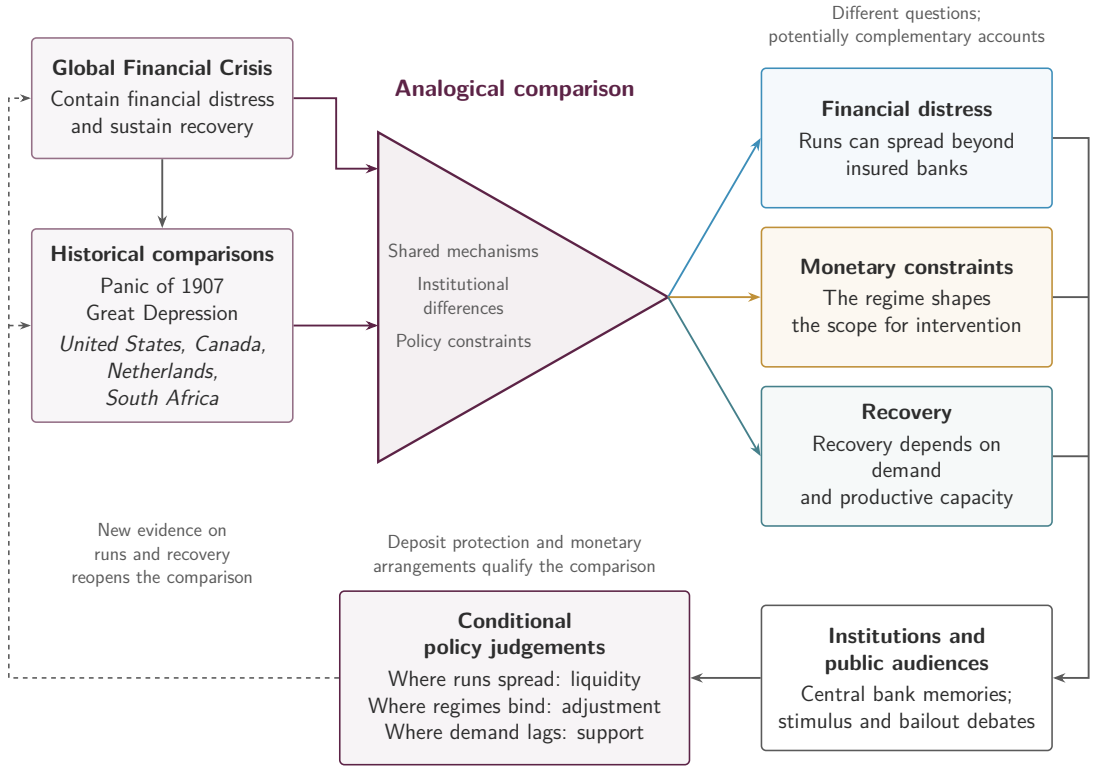



Figure 2: The Global Financial Crisis application of the narrative prism. Historical comparisons support three potentially complementary perspectives on financial distress, monetary constraints and recovery. Institutional memories and public debate shape their interpretation, while new evidence can prompt a revised comparison. The figure summarises the retrospective application developed in Sections 3–5.

together. Applied to our example, this could involve examining an institution's claim to have learned from the Depression, asking how a particular interpretation became authoritative and what alternative readings might change.

Communicating these judgements also requires care in how uncertainty is expressed. Reviewing experiments in public science communication, Gustafson and Rice (2020) find that reports of disagreement among scientists more often reduced credibility, whereas quantified uncertainty generally had neutral or positive effects in the studies reviewed, with responses varying by audiences' prior beliefs and worldviews. Telling policymakers merely that "historians disagree" about the 1930s can obscure both the grounds of disagreement and the evidence on which an assessment rests. Uncertainty about the strength of a transmission mechanism should be distinguished from uncertainty about whether financial disruption mattered at all, and advice should

specify which mechanisms depend on conditions that have changed and what new observations would warrant revising it.

Figure 2 brings these considerations together with the selection and comparison of historical evidence. The financial fragility, monetary constraint and recovery perspectives enter debates shaped by institutional responsibilities and public concerns. An account that supports emergency lending may leave questions about accountability unresolved, and a case for further stimulus may encounter an institution whose historical understanding centres on price stability. Applied economic history therefore involves examining how an argument is interpreted as well as assessing its evidential basis. Whether it influences a decision, and whether its qualifications survive that process, remain questions for investigation.

# 6 Applying the prism during a pandemic

Suppose that in April 2020 a finance ministry asks whether restrictions already introduced to contain Covid-19 should be maintained, modified or relaxed. Economic activity has fallen, but neither the course of the epidemic nor the consequences of changing policy are known. The ministry's policy officials must weigh the immediate economic costs of restrictions against the disruption that uncontrolled transmission might cause, then communicate their advice to the politicians responsible for the decision. Do protecting health and supporting economic activity involve a trade-off, or might they reinforce one another? And how might this relationship change over time as people respond to the disease and to the restrictions?

Whereas the Global Financial Crisis illustrated the prism's principles in retrospect, this second application places the historian inside an unfolding decision. We restrict the historical scholarship informing the advice to work published before January 2020.[4] This restriction shows what historical scholarship could offer before research responding to Covid-19 became available. The purpose is to consider what policymakers could

4. This cutoff excludes research that policymakers could nevertheless have consulted in April. Circulating their findings from as early as 27 March, Correia, Luck, and Verner (2020) argued from 1918 data that US cities intervening earlier and more extensively experienced stronger subsequent economic recovery. The published article moderates this claim and instead emphasised that interventions did not worsen economic outcomes (Correia, Luck, and Verner 2022). Advice based on working papers should acknowledge their provisional findings and explain how recommendations would change if those findings did not hold.

have learned from that scholarship and how the prism could have informed their deliberations, rather than to judge their choices with hindsight.

In spring 2020, the 1918 influenza pandemic was a comparison ready to hand. Familiarity alone, however, does not establish relevance. In Morgan's (1997) terms, the analogy requires examining both positive features, such as restrictions on social contact, and negative features, including differences in the disease and the societies affected. For the ministry's question, variation in the restrictions adopted by cities and in their timing offers evidence for assessing intervention, without assuming that Covid-19 would repeat the course of 1918. Examining 17 and 43 American cities respectively, Hatchett, Mecher, and Lipsitch (2007) and Markel et al. (2007) both associated earlier, sustained interventions with lower mortality peaks, while Hatchett, Mecher, and Lipsitch (2007) found a weaker relationship with cumulative mortality. The ministry would therefore need to distinguish reducing a peak from preventing deaths over the whole epidemic. Neither study establishes the economic return to restrictions.

For a ministry considering relaxation, the sequence after intervention is particularly informative. Renewed mortality waves followed the lifting of measures in cities examined by Hatchett, Mecher, and Lipsitch (2007). Bootsma and Ferguson's (2007) modelling of 16 cities explains why this could happen: effective controls could leave a population susceptible to renewed transmission when those controls ended. Falling deaths would therefore be an ambiguous signal. They might indicate that restrictions were working, without establishing that their removal was safe. The ministry would need contemporary evidence about the epidemic and about replacement measures to assess what would prevent renewed transmission and justify a reopening date.

Nor should the ministry assume that economic activity would return to normal once legal restrictions ended. Newspaper reports assembled by Garrett (2007) describe workers incapacitated by influenza and disrupted transport and communications, alongside falling retail sales. They identify ways in which disease interrupted activity without isolating the effects of government orders. Bootsma and Ferguson's (2007) model likewise fitted mortality better when it allowed contact to change in response to the epidemic as well as to official controls, although the authors could not distinguish deliberate avoidance from the effects of illness and caring responsibilities. Whether activity was falling because of government orders, illness or avoidance mattered for

the ministry's scenarios, because each has different implications for recovery once restrictions are lifted.

Comparing places also exposes differences that qualify the analogy. Clay, Lewis, and Severnini (2018) find that air pollution amplified mortality during the 1918 pandemic in American cities. Differences in deaths could therefore reflect underlying vulnerability as well as the timing of intervention, and apparently successful restrictions in one city need not have the same effect elsewhere. Moreover, schools, churches and theatres often closed together, limiting the scope to separate their effects (Hatchett, Mecher, and Lipsitch 2007). The ministry could use these comparisons to question an undifferentiated policy package, but not to rank individual restrictions without further evidence. Extending relatively short historical interventions into a much longer programme would require additional assumptions about compliance and economic costs.

The scale of intervention also changes the comparison. The American studies examine variation between cities, whereas the hypothetical ministry of this example could be considering restrictions across a national economy. Applying their findings requires asking how movement between places affected transmission and whether local economic activity depended on supplies or demand from areas under different restrictions. Nationwide measures could change these relationships, so their effects cannot be inferred simply by adding up local outcomes. The historical evidence can inform reasoning about the timing of intervention without establishing the aggregate consequences of coordinated national restrictions.[5] The ministry would need to judge when mechanisms remain relevant when the scale of the policy changes.

The 2003 SARS outbreak provides a different check on the ministry's economic scenarios. Examining national and sectoral statistics after SARS, Keogh-Brown and Smith (2008) found smaller losses in economic output than contemporary forecasts had suggested, with many disruptions concentrated in a short period. Their reconstruction does not cleanly separate disease, behavioural responses and policy, and SARS was far more geographically contained than Covid-19. But it draws attention to the duration assumed in translating an immediate loss into an aggregate forecast. The ministry could

5. This difference in scale was recognised during the pandemic. In an interview recorded on 16 April and published on 6 May 2020, Tooze (2020a) distinguished local interventions in 1918 from the comprehensive national restrictions adopted in 2020.

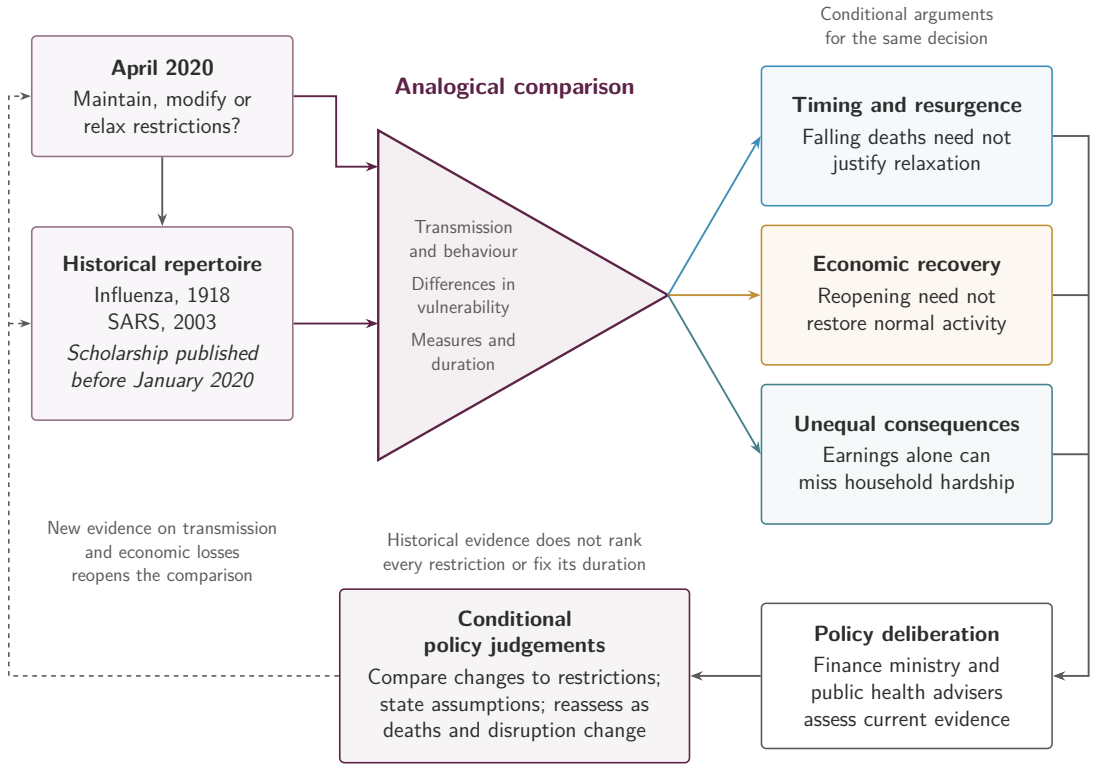



Figure 3: Applying the narrative prism to a hypothetical pandemic policy decision in April 2020. Research published before January 2020 informs comparisons of intervention, economic recovery and unequal consequences. The resulting arguments require assessment against contemporary evidence; they do not determine a single policy response. Dashed arrows indicate revision as new evidence becomes available.

assume neither rapid recovery nor prolonged contraction without examining what would sustain disruption. Each scenario would need to distinguish spending postponed from spending lost. The SARS comparison thus qualifies the economic use of 1918 without supplying a preferred forecast of its own.

Recovery would also look different depending on what the ministry measured. In Sweden, Karlsson, Nilsson, and Pichler (2014) find that the 1918 pandemic increased poorhouse rates and reduced capital returns, but had no discernible effect on earnings. An earnings measure alone would therefore have missed important economic consequences. In Norway, Mamelund's (2006) evidence from Kristiania (now Oslo) links mortality to housing and residential circumstances after accounting for demographic differences. Together, these studies direct attention towards households' exposure to disease and their capacity to absorb economic losses. Assessing whether

restrictions could be sustained, and what assistance should accompany them, would require evidence on hardship alongside aggregate activity. Neither the Swedish pattern nor the Norwegian social gradient could simply be presumed to recur.

Brought together through the narrative prism (Figure 3), pre-2020 scholarship would not hand the minister a single reopening date. Instead, the advice would set out competing scenarios for maintaining, modifying or relaxing restrictions, making explicit their assumptions about transmission and the duration of economic disruption. It would caution that falling deaths alone did not establish that reopening was safe, that illness and avoidance could depress activity even if rules were lifted, and that aggregate earnings could miss household hardship. Morgan's (2022) treatment of narrative as a tool for scientific reasoning helps explain the purpose: each scenario connects evidence into an account whose assumptions can be examined. Those accounts must also consider how people interpret events and act on their expectations, a concern central to Shiller's (2019) narrative economics. Uncertainty would become more specific: which observations supported each scenario, whose circumstances made the measures difficult to sustain, and what evidence would warrant revision. Historical reasoning would help policymakers judge the grounds for their choices while recognising how those choices could prove mistaken.

Real-time commentary by economic historians during 2020 shows both the promise and the difficulty of doing this work under pressure. Even before Western lockdowns began, James (2020) warned in *Project Syndicate* that the virus could trigger an interwar-style retreat from globalisation. As countries locked down in March, Colvin and McLaughlin (2020a) drew on 1918 in *The Conversation* to argue for early containment and economic support, including for workers whose circumstances made isolation difficult. Tumbe (2020) drew on India's 1918 influenza experience in *Mint* to warn how quickly a pandemic could overwhelm an unprepared country, and Tooze (2020b) argued in *The Guardian* that deliberate shutdowns resembled wartime mobilisation rather than a conventional recession. In April, Fourie (2020) used three centuries of pandemic mortality benchmarks in South Africa's *Finweek* to highlight the costs of behavioural avoidance, while warning that developing countries lacked the fiscal space of rich economies. Scheidel (2020) cautioned in *The New York Times* that, unlike the Black Death, Covid-19 would not compress inequality through labour

scarcity, and Eichengreen (2020) drew on past downturns in *The Guardian* to challenge claims of a rapid V-shaped rebound.

Later in the year, commentary turned to longer-run adjustments and distributional consequences. Colvin (2020) assessed the evidence on restrictions and their economic consequences in the *Economics Observatory*, stressing the need to combine findings across disciplines and account for differences in historical context. Hautcœur (2020) looked to interwar debt history in *Le Monde* to propose a one-off levy on large fortunes. Colvin and McLaughlin (2020b) showed in the *Irish Times* how population age structure affected comparisons of mortality across countries, and Alfani (2020) used European plague and cholera records on *VoxEU* to warn that pandemics have typically widened inequality.[6]

Written as the pandemic unfolded, these contributions, including our own, invite renewed scrutiny under the principles developed here. Did early commentary move too readily from evidence about 1918 to recommendations for Covid-19? Did syntheses of the historical evidence give sufficient weight to the limits of transferring its lessons across eras and fiscal regimes? Did warnings about demographic measurement and distributional harm reach audiences able to use them when relevant decisions were being made?[7] These questions extend the assessment beyond the historical comparison to the choice of audience, the timing of communication and the interpretation of the argument. The next section considers the professional practices and relationships through which historians can develop that engagement.

# 7 Implications for the profession

Economic historians engaging with policy have a responsibility to make the reasoning behind their advice open to examination. Historical evidence rarely determines a policy choice on its own. Advising on policy involves judging which findings bear on the problem and how much weight those findings can support under different circumstances.

6. In September 2020, Ji and De Grauwe (2020) extended the Depression comparison of Eichengreen and O'Rourke (2009) discussed in Section 4 to the pandemic, arguing that less banking distress allowed faster recovery with continued policy support.

7. Similarly, did the production data used by Ji and De Grauwe (2020) substantiate their explanation of faster recovery, and did their analogy adequately distinguish disruption caused by disease and restrictions from financial distress?

Distinguishing these judgements from the historical findings themselves, and explaining what would warrant revision, makes the advice easier for policymakers and the public to assess. Sustaining this engagement depends partly on how the profession prepares economic historians and supports their work with policymakers.

Making judgement explicit is useful only if the explanation supporting it can be challenged. In their comparison of how economists and historians produce knowledge, Colvin and Wagenaar (2018) discuss research in terms of abduction, deduction and induction. A surprising observation may suggest a possible explanation, that explanation has implications that can be investigated, and the resulting evidence may require it to be revised. They identify a weakness shared by both disciplines when evidence is selected to confirm assumptions insulated from challenge. Applied economic history extends this scrutiny to the move from explanation to advice. Even a well-supported historical finding does not establish its relevance to the present problem, so structuring judgement involves making that further inference, and the trade-offs it entails, available for assessment (Colvin et al. 2026).

Historical context is part of this assessment. Changed conditions may invalidate a relationship established in another time or place. Historical inquiry can therefore establish limits to economic theory as well as supply evidence for it, a role developed by John Neville Keynes and examined by Colvin and Winfree (2019). The Dutch discussion in Section 4 illustrates the point: similar movements of deposits need not reflect the same motives, so the observed resemblance alone cannot determine the appropriate response. Likewise, the pandemic application in Section 6 shows why applying evidence from short city restrictions to longer national policy requires judging how scale changes the relevant mechanisms. Investigating such differences requires the methodological breadth defended by Humphries (2026). An archival finding may challenge an account built from aggregate data, and quantitative comparison may expose a weakness in a persuasive interpretation. Professional training should prepare economic historians to assess these forms of evidence together.

Teaching can develop this capacity by requiring participants to defend advice before they know how events turned out. Such exercises can draw on Neustadt and May's (1986) approach to scrutinising historical comparisons in decision-making. In one simulation, civil service economists reassess a historical industrial policy intervention

from the perspectives of departments with different responsibilities, developing advice under time pressure and revising it as further evidence emerges (Colvin et al. 2026). Undergraduate students could likewise use historical research to prepare a policy brief, defending their choice of precedents and explaining where the comparisons break down.

Continuing policy work requires institutional support for repeated engagement rather than one-off reports. Providing historical expertise alone is insufficient: as Beck (2006) shows, internally commissioned histories in HM Treasury and the Foreign Office remained unread or unused. *History & Policy*, a forum connecting historians with policymakers in the United Kingdom, offers a different form of provision through its seminars, briefings and exchanges with HM Treasury around recurring policy questions (Colvin et al. 2026).[8] But maintaining such relationships also depends on the historian's own institution. Writing from the perspective of African economic history, Fourie (2026) shows how publication incentives and uneven access to research resources affect who can undertake applied work and which audiences they address. If universities and funders are to support collaboration, they need to recognise the time involved, including contributions that cannot readily be attributed to a single publication or policy decision.

Publication incentives may also pull against the choice of outlet best suited to an application. Specialist journals and public-facing platforms provide opportunities for this work, but may receive less recognition than the publications favoured in hiring and promotion. The relatively new, peer-reviewed *Journal of Applied History* provides an academic forum for reflecting on how history is applied and scrutinising its uses. It also welcomes applications of economic history, although these have so far been less prominent.[9] Established during the Covid-19 pandemic, the *Economics Observatory* addresses policymakers, journalists, students and the wider public more directly, and its "Lessons from history" section presents historical research through questions of current interest.[10]

Reaching these audiences requires more than finding a suitable outlet. A policy brief or public contribution must preserve essential details and make the argument's

8. See https://historyandpolicy.org/.

9. Our screening of titles and abstracts in the *Journal of Applied History*, volumes 1–8 (2019–2026), supplemented by selected full-text checks, identifies 6 of 55 articles (10.9%) with a clear economic history focus. Including 9 adjacent or borderline contributions raises this share to 27.3%.

10. See https://brill.com/joah and https://economicsobservatory.com/topics/lessons-from-history.

limits intelligible, skills that require training and professional recognition (Fourie 2026). Alongside established publications, authors can build an audience through regular contributions of their own. Newsletters and blogs by Anton Howes, Brad DeLong, Ken Opalo, Virginia Postrel and Mark Koyama, alongside Johan Fourie's *Our Long Walk*, use short essays grounded in economic and institutional history to address contemporary debates, reaching thousands and in several cases tens of thousands of subscribers.[11] Such writing allows direct communication with policymakers and other readers without journalists mediating the selection and framing of the argument. Successive contributions can revisit a comparison or respond to objections, creating opportunities to reconsider an application, although access to an audience does not establish influence over its decisions.

Engagement can also involve working with communities to interpret the past, an approach developed within the field of public history. Hannan and Purdue (2024) show how this work in Ireland connects the investigation of institutional abuse with questions of accountability and redress. Historical interpretation becomes part of a debate about what is owed to those affected. Such questions can have an explicit economic dimension: Blight (2006) places contemporary arguments about reparations for slavery in the United States within a longer history of demands for pensions and compensation, while the Legacies of British Slavery project traces how compensation paid to British slave-owners after abolition entered British commerce, property and politics (Hall et al. 2014). In South Africa, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission recommended reparations for victims of apartheid-era human rights violations, but the payments eventually made were smaller and later than proposed, leaving wider questions of restitution and the persistent economic legacies of apartheid contested (Colvin 2006). Here public history and applied economic history meet in debates about who should provide redress, to whom and in what form.

These forms of engagement depend on historical research whose timetable rarely matches the pace of public and policy debate. A question motivating an archival project may have left the policy agenda before the findings become available (Fourie

11. See Anton Howes's *Age of Invention* (https://www.ageofinvention.xyz/), Brad DeLong's Substack (https://braddelong.substack.com/), Ken Opalo's *An Africanist Perspective* (https://www.africanistperspective.com/), Johan Fourie's *Our Long Walk* (https://www.ourlongwalk.com/), Virginia Postrel's Substack (https://vpostrel.substack.com/) and Mark Koyama's newsletter (https://www.markkoyama.com/).

2026). Conversely, much of the Depression research used during the Global Financial Crisis, and the 1918 influenza studies drawn on in spring 2020, had been undertaken years earlier. Their value for those decisions could hardly have been a condition for undertaking them. Economic historians need opportunities to bring existing findings into policy debate, but requiring every project to demonstrate an immediate application would weaken the research on which future advice depends.

That accumulated research gives policymakers access to experiences beyond the precedents most readily recalled: what Tosh (2022) calls an "inventory of alternatives". Choosing among them, however, requires judgement about their relevance to the problem at hand. The narrative prism makes those judgements open to scrutiny, from selecting cases and examining mechanisms to the institutional and public interpretation of the resulting arguments. Across the financial crisis and pandemic applications, historical comparisons raise doubts about apparently familiar problems while offering grounds for assessing possible responses. Their contribution may be to unsettle confidence in a favoured course of action. Applied economic history can make that uncertainty useful by identifying what an argument depends on and what evidence would give policymakers reason to reconsider it.

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